and using them to solve problems, describing 2D/ 3D shapes, or reading and drawing inferences from data.

Nearly all experts agree that the greatest challenge in online education was the absence of personalised interaction and innovation. "Offline learning itself poses challenges, where a one-size-fits-all model has scant regard for the diverse learning needs of children," says Rajesh Bhatia, educationist, founder and CEO, Treehouse Education, a pre-school group in Mumbai. Online education came with its own set of challenges. In Rapid Surveys conducted by Oxfam India, 84 per cent of the teachers in government schools admitted that they found it difficult to deliver education through remote mediums. Worse, they were unable to build emotional connects with their students or carry out meaningful assessments of their learning abilities.

"An online class does not just happen," says Sinha. "It's far tougher to keep students engaged on a virtual window; every activity has to be thoughtfully planned. It's crucial to design a lesson that is both functional and relatable." Lessons could not be content-heavy as that would make them monotonous. The learning experience had to be both appealing and also spark the learner's imagination. "It was a very steep learning curve for many schools," says Vishnu Karthik, director, Heritage Group of Schools, Delhi NCR, and CEO, Xperiential Learning Systems. A lack of resources and institutional support compounded the problem. Consequently, most schools ended up delivering the same monologic lessons facing the computer rather than the children.

According to Father Mathews K. Thomas of Don Bosco School, Delhi, and member of the CBSE Educators' Forum, in a class with a heterogeneous group of students, online teaching benefitted two kinds of students—the good ones and the weaker students. It gave good students, or those who could grasp concepts faster, time to do other things. The high cut-offs for college admission reflected the trend. "For weaker students," says Fr Mathew, "a recorded online class could be played 'n' number of times to clear doubts. Those who would earlier scrape through with pass marks showed improvement from 50-60 per cent to 70-80 per cent." It was the average student, those with no particular ambition, who fell between the two extremes, and who showed the greatest gap in learning, according to the educator.

Assessment was another area that online education failed to find a suitable answer for. It was difficult for many schools to ascertain exactly how much a student had learnt. In the absence of fair and quality testing, schools and parents were unable to identify the learning gaps in their children. Using unfair means became routine. Some schools, like South Point in Kolkata, adopted stringent methods such as proctoring by 14

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teachers with special devices, monitoring of windows and built-in authentication of question papers. Yet some students managed to beat the system. "We came across students who were facing the camera and ostensibly writing the exam but who actually had their private tutors helping them out," Jaidev Ghosh, vice-principal of the school, revealed. The school then got innovative in setting its questions, using diagrams, pie charts and geometrical constructions in mathematical problems, the answers to which could not be sourced from Google or other search engines.

Food for Sloth

Apart from learning disabilities among children, Covid confinement, loneliness and the lack of physical activity led to a rise in consumption of junk food. Junk food consumption among children was already high before the pandemic—a 2019 study by the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE) of 13,274 children aged 9–14 showed that 93 per cent ate packaged food, 68 per cent consumed packaged sweetened beverages more than once a week, 53 per cent ate these products at least once a day. And though there is no specific data on the rise of junk food consumption among children during Covid, there are enough global studies to suggest that this was indeed the case and would have been so in India too. This, in turn, led to a rise in cases of obesity, which had an impact on mental capacity too. "Physical activity is vital as it releases positive hormones," says Dr Barkha Pandey, a paediatrician at the Manipal Hospital in Delhi. A 2021 survey of 18,000 Delhi kids by Sportz Village Schools, a sports education organisation, revealed that over 51 per cent of the kids had unhealthy BMI (body mass index, a measure of an individual's health and weight), meaning that every second child was overweight post the lockdown.

Global research also shows that children with good social-emotional skills also perform better academically, have stronger friendships and familial ties and tend towards positive thoughts and behaviour. "School